ZikShare

ACADEMIC VAULT

UNIZIK FRESHER EDITION | 2026

Word, Excel and PowerPoint: Produce Assignments That Look Professional

The practical software skills behind clean reports, data work and presentations

DIGITAL SKILLS

Digital Skills

General Studies (GST / CED)
GST Directorate | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

Free to download. No fee, no payment step, no watermark.

Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

A well-formatted report signals care; a spreadsheet that recalculates saves hours; a clear slide deck earns attention. This pack covers the specific features students actually need: styles, table of contents, page numbering, formulas, charts and presentation structure.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Format a long assignment using styles, headings and automatic page numbering.
- Insert a table of contents, figures and captions correctly.
- Use core Excel formulas, absolute references and simple charts.
- Design and deliver a short academic presentation.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Word: format once, not by hand

Manual formatting breaks the moment you edit. Use styles.

- Apply Heading 1, 2 and 3 styles to structure the document.
- Insert an automatic table of contents from the References tab.
- Add page numbers with a different first page where required.
- Use captions for figures and tables, then cross-reference them.
- Set consistent line spacing, margins and justified body text.
- Use track changes for group work and accept changes deliberately.

Excel: formulas that survive editing

The point of a spreadsheet is recalculation.

- Start every formula with equals and use cell references, not typed numbers.
- Relative references shift; dollar signs lock a row or column as absolute.
- Core functions: SUM, AVERAGE, COUNT, IF, VLOOKUP or XLOOKUP.
- Sort and filter before analysing; keep raw data on a separate sheet.
- Create charts from a clean table and label axes with units.
- Check totals independently rather than trusting the output.

> **The absolute reference habit**
> When copying a formula down a column, lock any cell it must keep referring to with dollar signs. This single habit prevents most spreadsheet errors.

PowerPoint: slides support you

Slides are visual aids, not a script.

- One idea per slide, stated in the title as a sentence.
- Use a readable font size and high contrast.
- Prefer a simple chart or diagram over a wall of text.
- Keep to a consistent template, colour and alignment.
- Rehearse timing and transitions; do not read the slides.
- Prepare for questions with two backup slides of evidence.

Word: structure first, appearance second

Most marks lost in typed assignments are lost to formatting chaos: inconsistent headings, manual numbering that breaks, paragraphs separated by blank lines, and a table of contents that does not match the page numbers. All of it disappears if you use styles properly.

Apply heading styles (Heading 1, Heading 2) rather than making text bold and large. Styles give you automatic navigation, a consistent look, and a working table of contents. Insert page numbers and a title page in separate sections so the numbering starts correctly.

Set the document up before writing: page size, margins, font, line spacing and the citation style your department requires. Then use Find and Replace for repeated corrections rather than editing by hand.

Excel: formulas, references and charts

A spreadsheet is a calculation engine. Every cell can hold a value or a formula beginning with equals. Relative references (A1) shift when copied; absolute references (A1) do not. Understanding that difference is the difference between a working model and a column of wrong answers.

The functions students actually need: SUM, AVERAGE, COUNT, IF, VLOOKUP or XLOOKUP, and ROUND. The IF function returns different values depending on a condition; lookups pull a value from a table based on a key. Learn these five and you can build a grade tracker, a budget, or a simple data analysis.

Charts should show one thing clearly. Title the axes, label the units, and choose the chart type that matches the relationship: column for comparison, line for change over time, pie only for a small number of parts of a whole.

> **Never type a number twice**
> If a value appears in two places, one of them should be a formula. Typed duplicates are how spreadsheets drift out of agreement.

PowerPoint: slides support a speaker

A slide is not a document. If the audience is reading paragraphs, they are not listening. One idea per slide, six lines maximum, large font, and a headline that states the point rather than naming the topic.

Design for the room: high contrast, dark text on a light background or the reverse, a font size readable from the back, and images that are relevant rather than decorative. Avoid animations unless they explain something.

Rehearse with the slides, not by reading them. Keep notes in the speaker notes pane. Always export a PDF copy and carry it on a flash drive, because equipment fails and the version on someone else's laptop is not always the version you saved.

WORKED EXAMPLES

Do it once, slowly

These are not model answers to copy. They show the reasoning a strong student would use, step by step, so you can repeat the process on a question you have not seen.

1. A working grade tracker

You want to compute your CGPA in Excel.

1. Columns: course code, units, score, grade.
2. Use nested IF formulas to convert score to grade and grade point.
3. Multiply each grade point by its unit value.
4. Sum the weighted points and the units separately.
5. Divide the total weighted points by total units.
6. Freeze the header row and apply conditional formatting to highlight low grades.

> **What to carry forward**
> Convert to numbers early, weight by units, divide at the end.

2. Fixing a Word document that will not behave

Your headings are inconsistent and the table of contents is wrong.

1. Select each heading and apply the correct built-in style.
2. Remove manual bold and font-size changes.
3. Insert an automatic table of contents from References.
4. Update the field to refresh page numbers.
5. Insert page numbers with a section break after the title page.
6. Check the document in print preview.

> **What to carry forward**
> Styles are the fix. Manual formatting is the cause.

EXAM TECHNIQUE

Questions with model answers

Written in the shape your course is usually examined, with the marking logic spelled out. Attempt each one under time before you read the outline.

Q1. Explain the difference between relative and absolute cell references.

10 marks

1. Relative references change when copied.
2. Absolute references are fixed with dollar signs.
3. Give one use case for each.
4. Explain what goes wrong if the distinction is ignored.

Q2. Why should headings in a long document use styles rather than manual formatting?

10 marks

1. Consistency across the document.
2. Automatic table of contents and navigation.
3. Easier global changes.
4. Manual formatting breaks when text is edited.

REFERENCE

Glossary

Use these definitions in your own sentences; a copied definition rarely earns full marks.

Style. A saved set of formatting rules applied to text such as a heading.

Section break. A division in a document allowing different formatting or numbering.

Field. An automatically updated element such as a page number or contents list.

Cell reference. The address of a spreadsheet cell, such as A1.

Absolute reference. A fixed cell reference that does not change when copied.

Function. A built-in calculation such as SUM or IF.

Lookup. A function that retrieves a value from a table using a key.

Conditional formatting. Formatting applied automatically according to cell values.

Chart type. The visual form used to display a data relationship.

Speaker notes. Text visible to the presenter but not the audience.

Your four-week plan

Week 1 - Word

Structure.

- Set up a template with styles.
- Insert automatic contents and page numbers.
- Convert an old assignment to styles.

Week 2 - Excel

Formulas.

- Build a grade tracker.
- Practise relative and absolute references.
- Use IF and one lookup.

Week 3 - Charts

Communication.

- Create three charts from one data set.
- Label axes and units.
- Choose the right type and justify it.

Week 4 - Slides

Presentation.

- Build ten slides at six lines maximum.
- Rehearse with notes.
- Export a PDF backup.

Where to read more

Entry-level texts you can find in the university library or a departmental reading list. Confirm editions with your lecturer.

- A short guide to Word styles and long-document formatting.
- An Excel formulas tutorial covering IF and lookups.
- Your department's formatting and citation requirements.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. Why use Word styles instead of manual formatting?

Answer: Styles apply consistent formatting and allow automatic tables of contents, navigation and easier edits.

2. What does a dollar sign do in an Excel reference?

Answer: It locks the column or row so the reference does not change when the formula is copied.

3. Write a formula to average cells B2 to B10.

Answer: =AVERAGE(B2:B10)

4. How many ideas should a slide carry?

Answer: One. Additional ideas belong on separate slides.

5. How do you verify an Excel total independently?

Answer: Recalculate using a different method, such as manual addition or a separate formula, and compare the results.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Format a two-page document using heading styles.
- [ ] Insert an automatic table of contents and page numbers.
- [ ] Add a captioned table and cross-reference it in the text.
- [ ] Build a 20-row spreadsheet with at least three formulas.
- [ ] Create one chart with labelled axes and units.
- [ ] Design a five-slide presentation on a course topic.
- [ ] Present it to a friend and take feedback on clarity.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date:

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